

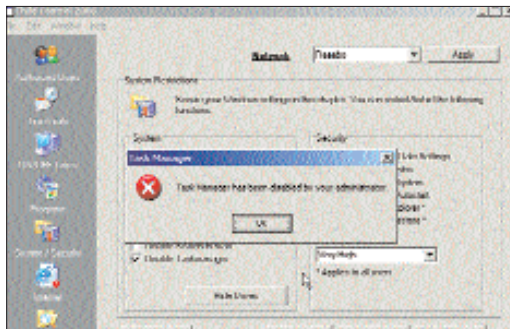
Content Blocking Software

Child Control 2006

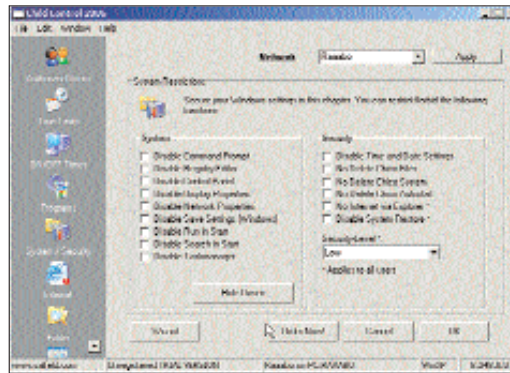
You can get this software at www.salfeld.com. It's just a 5.3 MB download. Installation and configuration are a breeze, as is the case with almost all the software in this test. I used the 30-day trial, which is not limited in any way in terms of functionality.

As soon as I was done installing, I got a very useful configuration screen. I found that I could disable the Command Prompt, Registry Editor, Task Manager, Control Panel, Display Properties, and many more controls by which a really geeky teen could attempt to disable the program. The software allows you to control/filter Internet content that deals with a variety of subjects, such as pornography (obviously), violence, alcohol, gambling, weapons, and drugs. It can even block chat!

I started with a Google search for some "bad" words, and was immediately shown a page that told me such content was banned. I then navigated to a well-known porn site, and I was blocked again.



Child Control 2006 blocks the Task Manager so that your kids cannot just End Task the application



Child Control 2006 gives you a list of security options

Next, I went to a not-so-famous porn site and found that, despite all the dirty words on the page, it loaded. Child Control 2006 (CC06) was definitely not doing a smart job here, and was just reading from a database.

I then raised the protection level and found that the software was doing a much better job.

However, there was still no image blocking, and our "Innocuous Site" test (see box *How I Tested*) seemed to easily thwart it.

Overall, Child Control 2006 did about as well as anyone would expect it to, and the cool features of disabling all backdoor ways of bypassing it make it a good choice. Another very handy feature, which has nothing to do with content filtering, is the software's ability to enforce *your* rules in the house regarding PC usage. You can specify how many hours a day your children can use the computer, and until what time. So there's no need to keep looking in on them and telling them to "turn off that computer at once"; just configure the software and then rest easy knowing that your kids will *have* to go to bed early on school nights!

Child Control 2006 costs \$29.90 (Rs 1,350). It happens to be the cheapest paid software in this test.

How I Tested

I chose nine content filtering software based on popularity. Seven of these were the most popular choices, and two were freeware tools that I felt people would want as options to the paid software. The test procedure was simple: install the software, configure it, and then try and find ways around it. I didn't attempt any Registry hacking or ultra-geeky ways of bypassing the software's protection because I wanted to keep the test real. If you have an über-geek for a child, no software is going to stop him or her from finding what they want online.

My test system was an AMD 64 3000+ with 1 GB of RAM and an 80 GB SATA hard drive, running Windows XP Professional with Service Pack 2 installed. All the latest drivers for the hardware were installed, and apart from Internet Explorer, I installed Mozilla FireFox 1.5.0.4, and already had Opera 9.00 beta (build 8367) installed.

After installing the content blocking software, I first navigated to Google, and used its Web and Image searches to try and find keywords that would bring up adult content without being blocked. I then had a few sites that had very innocuous-sounding URLs, but contained a lot of nudity. This was to test if the software was actually scanning images, looking for a lot of flesh, based on colour. Sadly, I can report right now that none of

the software I tested here actually do this—all of them failed this test miserably!

Apart from this, I also navigated to sites that I know contain a lot of text about sex and violence, and checked if the software would block that. Right at the outset, it seemed that most of the software were only blocking based on their databases rather than actually looking at the text or images on the pages. I tested each software with the normal and a higher protection level (if it was available). The results of the highest protection setting are noted in the table, but are not deciding factors for me. I chose to only pit each software's default setting against the other.

I obviously cannot provide you with the links to the sites that I tested the software on, but I mainly tried to fool each software using Google's search results to find adult content.

Since it's obvious that the most important thing for parents would be how the software performed, Performance scores got a 50 per cent weightage in my decision. I gave Ease of Use and Configuration a generous 10 per cent weightage: not too many parents would be able to configure the advanced settings on their own! We in India love our "free" software, so I decided that price would be 20 per cent of the deciding factor. Finally, the Features of a software merited 20 per cent of their overall tally.